

for a photo like I was at the Department of Motor Vehicles and then gave me a \$5,000 credit limit on a bright red plastic card.

Five thousand dollars. Whoa. I'd never seen \$5,000 in any account belonging to me in my entire life.

In the photo, I'm not smiling, and my scarf is wrapped tightly around my neck and over my chin. You can barely see my face. Every time I took the card out of my wallet, it felt like a mirror of my credit-related emotions. Even though I had it, I never looked into what the credit card was for. I never clicked around on the BoA website and checked out my cash rewards or how to get them. I must have known they existed. The card said "cash rewards" right on it. I didn't trust the wording. The whole thing felt like a loaded gun. A trick. Once they got your name and address, they could charge you for all kinds of stuff, and there was nothing you could do. Was I opting into a scam? I slowly started using the card, and though I often got close to maxing it out, I could mostly pay the small minimum and keep the party going.

In August 2017, after having the same credit card for five years, I finally made an appointment at my local Bank of America location, vaguely saying I wanted to "talk about credit cards." I'd never met with anyone at the bank to talk about anything. I allotted an hour for this chat, and I was ready for embarrassment and confusion. But actually, I was in and out in twenty minutes. Here's how it went down:

After a few minutes of relaxing in the waiting chairs (good call on my part!), I was ushered over to a cubicle by a tall bald guy named Tig. Tig showed me that I had \$215 in cash rewards that I'd never redeemed. Cash rewards, or cash back, is extra money you get when you use your credit on certain types of expenditures. Each credit card has a different system for rewards (and some have none at all). For example, when I use my card to purchase groceries and gas, a certain percentage of that money is returned to my account as a reward for what I've spent, so I try to be mindful of how I'm using my credit card to maximize the potential for rewards.

At the time I didn't know any of this. Tig helped me redeem my cash rewards (\$215! Sitting there!) and set up my account for auto redemption, so that every time the cash rewards hit \$25, the money goes directly to my checking account.